

Aloe vera syn. *A. barbadensis* (Xanthorrhoeaceae)

Aloe Vera, Aloes

Native to Africa, aloe vera is commonly cultivated as a potted plant and has two distinct types of medicinal use. The clear gel contained in the leaf is a remarkably effective healer of wounds and burns, speeding up the rate of healing and reducing the risk of infection. The yellow sap from the base of the leaf when dried is known as “bitter aloes.” It is a strong laxative, useful for short-term constipation.



Aloe vera has prickly, gray-green, succulent leaves that yield effective medicinal substances.

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to eastern and southern Africa, aloe vera grows wild in the tropics and is cultivated extensively worldwide. (Aloe vera plants grown as potted plants have a low anthraquinone content.) Aloe vera is propagated by breaking off small rooted plantlets. To collect the gel and bitter liquid, the leaves are cut and drained.

Related Species

Cape aloes (*A. ferox*) is used in herbal medicine as an irritant laxative. Many other *Aloe* species are also useful medicinally.

Key Constituents

- Anthraquinones (aloin, aloe-emodin)
- Resins
- Tannins
- Polysaccharides
- Aloectin B

Key Actions

- Heals wounds
- Emollient

- Stimulates secretions of bile
- Laxative

Research

■ **Healing properties** Extensive research since the 1930s in the U.S. and Russia has shown that the clear gel has a dramatic ability to heal wounds, ulcers, and burns, putting a protective coat on the affected area and speeding up the rate of healing. This action is in part due to the presence of aloectin B, which stimulates the immune system.

Traditional & Current Uses

- **Beauty treatment** Aloe vera has a long history as a skin lotion—Cleopatra is said to have attributed her beauty to it.
- **Western remedy** In the West, aloe vera first became popular in the 1950s when its ability to heal burns, in particular radiation burns, was discovered.
- **First aid** Aloe vera is an excellent first aid remedy for burns, scrapes, scalds, and sunburn. A leaf, broken off, releases soothing gel, which may be applied to the affected part.
- **Skin conditions** The gel is useful for almost any skin condition that needs soothing and astringing, and will help varicose veins to some degree.
- **Ulcers** The protective and healing effect of aloe vera also works internally, and the gel can be used for peptic ulcers and irritable bowel syndrome.
- **Laxative** The bitter yellow liquid in the leaves (bitter aloes) contains anthraquinones, which are strongly laxative. They cause the colon



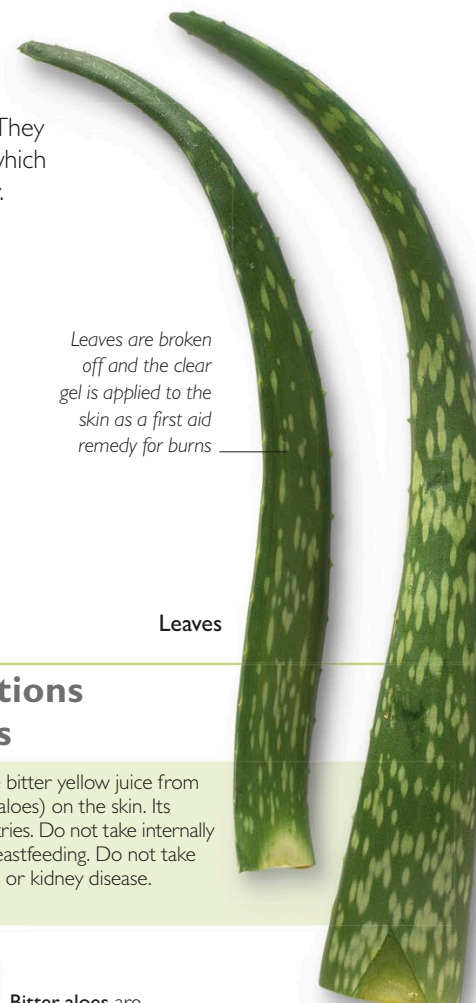
Aloe vera
A perennial with succulent leaves 2 ft (60 cm) long and a spike of yellow or orange flowers.

Parts Used

Leaves exude a bitter liquid, which is dried and known as “bitter aloes.” They also contain a clear gel, which is a soothing skin remedy.



Chopped leaves



Leaves

Leaves are broken off and the clear gel is applied to the skin as a first aid remedy for burns

Key Preparations & Their Uses

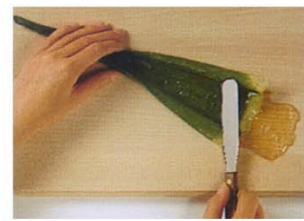
❗ **Cautions** Do not use the bitter yellow juice from the base of the leaves (bitter aloes) on the skin. Its use is restricted in some countries. Do not take internally during pregnancy or while breastfeeding. Do not take if suffering from hemorrhoids or kidney disease.



Bitter aloes are used by herbalists to treat constipation.



Juice is made commercially from the gel. For peptic ulcers, take 2½ tbsp 3 times a day.



Leaves Break off a leaf and split open to collect the gel. For burns and eczema, apply liberally twice a day.

🌿 **Tincture** made from bitter aloes (see p. 292). To stimulate the appetite, take 3 drops with water before meals.

to contract, generally producing a bowel movement 8–12 hours after consumption. At low doses, the bitter properties of the herb stimulate digestion. At higher doses, bitter aloes are laxative and purgative.

Self-help Uses

- **Minor burns & sunburn**, p. 303.
- **Stretch marks**, p. 317.
- **Warts**, p. 304.
- **Weeping skin**, p. 303.
- **Wounds**, p. 304.